number of its remaining cadres during the US counter-attack. The organization split when some members left to form Harkat-ul-Mujahideen-al-Alami (Alami means ‘international’) in response to the leadership’s unwillingness to break ties with the state. JeM was the largest and best-funded Deobandi group fighting in Indian-administered Kashmir by the time of the 9/11 attacks. But it was a new group, organizationally fractious, with a weak ideological foundation. As early as October 2001, JeM gunmen were targeting Westerners and Christians inside Pakistan in retaliation for the US counter-attack in Afghanistan.[2] Its leader, Maulana Azhar, is believed to have expelled some of those who were involved in the October 2001 attacks in order to avoid his own arrest.[3] In response to this action, as well as Azhar’s general willingness to continue working with the army and ISI, many Jaish members left and joined those who were expelled to form the splinter group Jamaat-ul-Furqan. Both the HuM and JeM splinters suffered harsh reprisals at the hands of the security services.

Lashkar was the most reliable in Islamabad’s eyes and fared the best. To begin with, it benefited from stronger connections to Pakistan’s army, ISI and civil service than other groups. Several journalists pointed out that, in addition to having recruited retired army and ISI officers into its ranks, Lashkar members had family in the middle ranks of the army and various civilian security agencies. Thus, the group was better connected than any other militant out-fit.[4] It also had no strong allegiance to the Taliban and therefore was viewed as less of a threat to the state. According to one former senior official in the Intelligence Bureau, the government ordered Lashkar not to side with the Taliban in the immediate aftermath of 9/11. When it complied, this reinforced the perception that it was an obedient and reliable proxy.[5] Finally, Lashkar’s leadership shared Musharraf’s India-centric priorities and the group remained Pakistan’s most potent proxy. One Western diplomat stationed in Pakistan went so far as to suggest the Musharraf regime would have sacrificed the other outfits if necessary in order to protect Lashkar because of its utility against India.[6] The result was that, as a former high-ranking ISI official explained, ‘because Lashkar responded differently [than the Deobandi groups] in the post-9/11 environment it was treated differently,’[7] But Lashkar was playing a double game of its own.